

Marking should be positive, rewarding achievement rather than penalising failure or omissions. The award of marks **must be** directly related to the marking criteria.

- Each band descriptor covers all the relevant content for the topic areas
- The descriptors should be read and applied as a whole
- Make a best fit match between the answer and the band descriptors
- An answer does not have to meet all of the requirements of a band descriptor before being placed in that band. It will be placed in a particular band when it meets more of the requirements of that band than it meets the requirements of other bands
- Where there is more than one strand within the band descriptors for a topic area and a strand has not been addressed at all, it is still possible for the answer to be credited within that mark band depending upon the evidence provided for the remaining strands. The answer should be placed in the mark band most closely reflecting the standard achieved across all strands within the band descriptors for topic areas; however in this scenario, the mark awarded for that band should reflect that a strand has not been addressed.

When deciding the mark within a band, the criteria below should be applied:

- the extent to which the statements within the band have been achieved. For example:
 - an answer that convincingly meets nearly all of the requirements of a band descriptor should be placed at or near the top of that band. Where the student's work convincingly meets the statements, the highest mark should be awarded
 - an answer that meets many of the requirements of the band descriptor should be placed in the middle of the band. Where the student's work adequately meets the statements, the most appropriate mark in the middle range should be awarded
 - if an answer is on the borderline between two bands but it is decided that it better fits the descriptors for:
 - the lower of these two bands - it should be placed near the top of the lower band
 - the higher of these two bands - the lowest mark for the higher band should be awarded. If a student's answer does not meet any Mark Band 1 (MB1) criteria for the task, you must award zero marks for that task.

Teachers/assessors should use the full range of marks available to them and award full marks in any band for work that fully meets that descriptor. This is work that is 'the best one could expect from students working at that level'.